

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 5.1

RHYTHM

REGULAR AND IRREGULAR METERS

DUPLE AND TRIPLE METERS AND RHYTHMIC GROUPINGS



“REGULAR” METERS AND MEASURES

When the pulse in a piece of music can be organized into **regular patterns** of strong and weak beats, we say that the music has **regular meter**. The music is divided into units called **measures**, using a vertical stroke called a **bar line**.

Bar lines were first used in Western staff notation in instrumental dance music, and by convention, imply that the beat following the bar line, called a **downbeat**, is strong in comparison to those that follow.

Examples of regular meter would be:

ONE-two | ONE-two | ONE-two | ONE-two or

ONE-two-three | ONE-two-three | ONE-two-three | ONE-two-three or

ONE-two-THREE-four | ONE-two-THREE-four | ONE-two-THREE-four, etc.

The following three examples illustrate various types of regular meter found in liturgical hymns:

EX. 1 - DUPLÉ METER IN CUT TIME

1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2

Al - le - lu - ia, al - le -

1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2 1 2

lu - ia, al - le - lu - ia.

EX. 2 - TRIPLE METER IN CUT TIME

Slowly.

1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3

Let us who — mys - ti - c'ly rep - re - sent the

1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3 1 2 3

Cher - u - bim, rep - re - sent — the Cher - u - bim,

Ex. 3 - DUPLÉ METER IN COMMON TIME

1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

Let us who mys-ti-c'ly, let us who mys - ti - c'ly,

The image shows a musical staff in common time (C) with a treble clef. The melody consists of eighth and quarter notes. Above the staff, the first four beats of each of the five measures are numbered 1 through 4. Below the staff, the lyrics are written under the notes: 'Let us who mys-ti-c'ly, let us who mys - ti - c'ly,'. The first measure has a half note 'Let' and a quarter note 'us'. The second measure has a quarter note 'who' and a half note 'mys-ti-c'ly,'. The third measure has a quarter note 'let' and a half note 'us'. The fourth measure has a quarter note 'who' and a half note 'mys'. The fifth measure has a quarter note 'ti', a quarter note 'c'ly,', and a whole rest.

“ON THE SPOT” EXERCISE

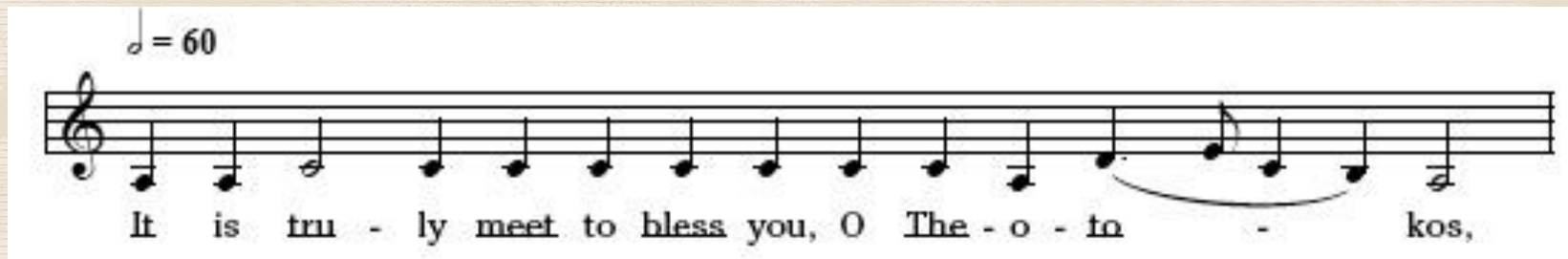
In the three preceding examples, sight-read the rhythm, using Kodály syllables and keeping a steady beat. Remember to assign the correct syllable (**ta**) to the pulse.

These examples are written in the key of C, where the note C = DO. Print out Slides 3 and 4 and write in the solfège syllables for the notes, then sight sing the melody using SOL-FA syllables.

EXAMPLE OF “IRREGULAR” METER

On the other hand, when there is no evident regularity to the patterns of strong and weak beats, the piece is said to have **irregular meter**. (Sometimes the term “unmetered” is used with regard to liturgical chant, but this is a misnomer. Although the meter may be constantly changing, determined by the **word stresses**, we can still identify **groupings** of strong and weak syllables.) For example, in the excerpt below, we first underline the word stresses:

EX. 4A

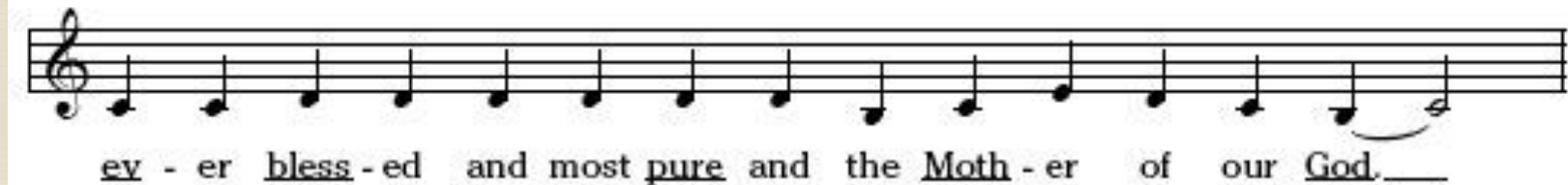


A musical staff in treble clef with a tempo marking of quarter note = 60. The melody consists of quarter notes and half notes. The lyrics are: "It is tru - ly meet to bless you, O The - o - to - kos,". The words "tru", "meet", "bless", "The", and "to" are underlined. A slur is placed over the final three notes, which correspond to the syllables "to", "to", and "kos".

With ONE as the strong beat, we get the following pattern:

ONE-two | ONE-two-three | ONE-two | ONE-two-three | ONE-two | ONE-two-three-four | ONE-two

(continued)



ONE-two | ONE-two-three-four | ONE-two-three | ONE - two - three - four | ONE-two-three

If we were to write this using customary **time signatures**, we would get the following:

Ex. 4B

It is tru - ly meet to bless you, O The-o - to - kos,

A musical staff in treble clef with a key signature of one flat (B-flat). The melody consists of quarter notes for 'It is', eighth notes for 'tru - ly', quarter notes for 'meet to', eighth notes for 'bless you,', quarter notes for 'O', eighth notes for 'The-o - to', and a half note for 'kos'. A slur is placed under the final 'kos' and the following two underscores.

ev - er bless - ed and most pure and the Moth - er of our God.__

A musical staff in treble clef with a key signature of one flat (B-flat). The melody consists of quarter notes for 'ev - er', eighth notes for 'bless - ed', quarter notes for 'and most', eighth notes for 'pure', quarter notes for 'and the', eighth notes for 'Moth - er', quarter notes for 'of our', and a half note for 'God'. A slur is placed under the final 'God' and the following two underscores.

“ON THE SPOT” EXERCISE

Following the given time signatures, count out each measure in the example on the previous slide. Read the rhythm using Kodály rhythmic syllables.

This example is written in the key of C, where C = DO. (Hint: the starting note is LA.) Write in the solfège syllables and sight-sing the music using SOL-FA syllables.

When patterns of strong and weak beats can be organized into groupings that are multiples of 2, they are said to be **duple meters** or **duple rhythmic groupings**. When the patterns of strong and weak beats fall into groups that are multiples of 3, they are called **triple meters** or **triple rhythmic groupings** (not be confused with **triplets**—3 notes in the time of 2, which are rarely, if ever, encountered in Orthodox church music). In order to preserve the natural inflection of liturgical texts, duple and triple rhythmic groupings are often mixed in passages of chant, causing the meter to be irregular.

The manner of writing out the time signatures as shown on the previous slide clearly demonstrates the **irregular, word-related** nature of the meter. But it also gives the musical score a somewhat cluttered appearance.

It is more common to see chant-style hymns that have an irregular, word-related meter to be written **without** time signatures or bar lines, as shown below. Some editions mark triple groupings by means of a **horizontal bracket** over the text, which alerts both the conductor and the singers to the proper inflection of the words.

Ex. 4c

The image displays two staves of musical notation for a chant-style hymn. The notation is written on a single staff with a treble clef and a key signature of one flat (B-flat). The melody consists of half notes and quarter notes. The lyrics are written below the staff, with horizontal brackets placed over certain words to indicate triple groupings. The first staff contains the lyrics: "It is tru - ly meet to bless you, O The - o - to - kos,". The second staff contains the lyrics: "ev - er bless - ed and most pure and the Moth - er of our God. —". The brackets are placed over "tru - ly", "bless you, O", "The - o - to", "pure and the", and "God. —".

When a triple rhythmic grouping occurs in the midst of duple meter moving in half-note pulse, it is sometimes called an **“extended beat,”** because it is, indeed, longer by one sub-unit of the pulse than the surrounding duple rhythmic groups.

Please proceed to **RHYTHM EXERCISES 5.1**

